The brickworks that woke up a country

Voiceover script · Durban, 1973 · about 43 seconds · 142 words · read at about 3.35 words per second

Chapter 1 - The brickworks (0:00)

In 1973, two thousand workers in Durban did something illegal. They stopped making bricks. It was the ninth of January, at the Coronation Brick and Tile works. They earned under nine rand a week, and they marched to a football stadium to demand more. But Black workers had no union, and striking was against the law.

Chapter 2 - The strike spreads (0:16)

Then the company offered one rand fifty more. They said no, and got just over two rand. Within weeks, six thousand Frame textile workers walked out too. By March, more than sixty thousand workers at over a hundred Durban firms had downed tools.

Chapter 3 - Why it worked (0:29)

You see, a boss can fire one worker. But no factory runs without all of them. So the government set up an inquiry. In 1979, it said Black unions should be recognised. It all started with two thousand people who stopped making bricks.